BEFORE

China was an important influence on the successive rulers of the Korean peninsula.

CHINESE INFLUENCE

In 668 CE, the Korean peninsula was unified by the Silla kingdom, which imported and adapted institutions, ideas, and technology from neighboring China. **Buddhism** became central to spiritual and political life during this period. During the **Koryo dynasty** (932–1392 CE), Buddhist art and scholarship flourished under state sponsorship. Among the ruling elite of scholar-officials, an intellectual import from Song-dynasty China « 162–63 began to gain ground: **Neo-Confucianism**.

A NEW DYNASTY

In 1392, a Koryo general called Yi Songgye seized power, declaring himself the first king of the new **Choson dynasty**. This provided the opportunity for the Neo-Confucians to sweep aside the economic power and "corrupting" political and moral influences of Buddhism.

78 MILLION **The number of Korean-speakers around the world who still use the letters of the phonetic han'gul script originally devised by King Sejong.**

Korea in the Middle Ages

The Choson kingdom dominated Korea from 1392 to 1910, making it one of history's most enduring royal dynasties. King Sejong is credited with laying the foundations of this longevity during his 32-year reign (1418–50). His greatest legacy is the invention of han'gul—an alphabet for the Korean language.

At the heart of Sejong's project was the implementation of the Neo-Confucian view of the world, which had been established as the official ideology of the dynasty by Sejong's grandfather Yi Songgye (see BEFORE). For the Neo-Confucians, human society was an integral part of a universe that included the natural world and the heavens and was governed by a pattern called li or "principle." Although it appeared to be abstract, Neo-Confucianism was an intensely pragmatic philosophy that defined the way in which humans should relate to one another socially and the way that society, and the king in particular, should interact with the wider natural world. The role of the ideal Neo-Confucian sage-king was to bring order to heaven and earth according to the requirements of li, and most importantly, to harmonize all aspects of human behavior with the underlying universal order. This was an ideal that Sejong ambitiously sought to realize in a way that no other Korean king before or since has done.

At the start of the Choson period, the aristocracy, which had grown powerful under the previous Koryo dynasty (see BEFORE), was forced to seek power through a revitalized civil service examination system, based on similar Chinese systems (see pp.128–29). This new ruling class, which combined features of a hereditary aristocracy and a scholarly bureaucracy, came to be called the yangban and remained the most powerful class in Choson society until the beginning of the 20th century.

In addition to maintaining his own ruling dynasty and strengthening the bureaucratic state, Sejong placed much importance on ensuring the well-being of his people through innovations that improved their lives.

INVENTION

RAIN GAUGE

Rain gauges, such as this stone, iron, and bronze example, were designed in the 1440s, long before such equipment was used in Europe. Each gauge was standardized to 16.5 in (42.5 cm) in height and 6.5 in (17 cm) in diameter. Sejong had them installed in every county so that local magistrates could record rainfall and contribute to knowledge of the climate and improvement of agricultural techniques. Other scientific achievements of 15th-century Korea were the development of water clocks and the publication of books on medicine, pharmacology, agriculture, and astronomy.

Sounds for the people

It is easy to identify King Sejong's most important innovation—the invention of the phonetic alphabet for the Korean language, called han'gul. As far as contemporary Koreans are concerned, it is a central aspect of everyday life and a source of national pride, but when the king first introduced the alphabet in the mid-15th century, the new writing system seemed to the intellectual elite of the time to be a vulgarization of written language. Writing in Korea had hitherto been limited to complex Chinese characters and was the exclusive property of the yangban. Many yangban resented these simple and relatively easy-to-learn new characters, which for a long time were used mainly by women.

The king explained his motivation for creating the script in his preface to a work illustrating the new writing system,